

ANGEL ACTION · AIRWAY

Choking — Adult, Child and Infant

For a person who cannot cough, speak or breathe, give 5 sharp back blows between the shoulder blades, then 5 chest thrusts, and alternate until the airway clears or they become unconscious.

Recognise choking

- **Mild (effective cough):** the person can still cough, speak or breathe. Encourage them to keep coughing.
- **Severe (ineffective cough):** silent cough, unable to speak or breathe, clutching the throat, lips turning blue. Act immediately.

Adult or child (over 1 year)

1. **Call 000** (or get someone else to).
2. Lean the person forward and give up to **5 sharp back blows** between the shoulder blades with the heel of your hand. Check the mouth after each.
3. If the obstruction has not cleared, give up to **5 chest thrusts** — same hand position as CPR but slower and sharper.
4. **Alternate** 5 back blows and 5 chest thrusts.
5. If they become **unconscious**, lower carefully to the ground and start **CPR**.

Infant (under 1 year)

1. **Call 000**.
2. Lay the baby face-down along your forearm, head lower than chest, supporting the head and jaw.
3. Give up to **5 firm back blows** between the shoulder blades.
4. Turn the baby face-up and give up to **5 chest thrusts** with 2 fingers on the lower sternum.
5. Alternate until the airway clears or the baby becomes unresponsive — then start infant CPR.

Do NOT

- Do not put your fingers blindly into the mouth — you may push the object further in.
- Do not perform abdominal thrusts (Heimlich) — Australian Resuscitation Council guidelines use back blows and chest thrusts.

*Adapted from **Australian First Aid 5th Edition**. Get the full guide and live CPR metronome at firstaidangel.org.*